PAROMITA BANERJEE, *53*

Entrepreneur, ***Kolkata***

Dream fulfilled: **Started her own handicraft and handloom business, Mohona**

How Covid changed me: **"I wouldn't have quit my job if it hadn't been for the pandemic and my friends who inspired me to follow my calling"**

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY



employment services, found in a 2021 survey that 63 per cent Indians would rather be unemployed than be unhappy in a job. Over half the respondents also said they would quit a job if it was preventing them from enjoying their life. In the case of Kolkata-based Sankhadeep Mitra, 46, this meant forfeiting a blossoming career in the banking industry and an annual salary of Rs 14 lakh—but a childhood dream beckoned. He had always loved food. As a child, he accompanied his father to the city's bustling fish and vegetable markets. He was hooked to the stories too—of which fish breeds when (and should therefore be avoided), or why seasonal greens are so vital. However, his banking career left no time for culinary pursuits. "It was only after Covid struck, and I saw death all around, that I realised life was short, transient and had to be lived to the full. I really needed to heed the calling from my inside," says Sankhadeep. That resulted in Zoom Tea-O-Graphy, a cafe-cum-art gallery. It has an old-world charm to it. Sankhadeep brought to it the feel of the North Kolkata he had grown up in—the world of Amherst Street and Shyam Bazar, where houses had patios and steps in front, where people sat for endless adda over tea and roadside fritters. Alongside his café, Sankhadeep added in another hobby—photography. "I'm now clicking away to my heart's content," he says.

Giving up a profession one has invested years and decades in is not easy. People reassessed their karmic selves. What exactly were they *doing* in their lives? Was their old business actually good enough to satisfy body and soul? If not, what else could they do? For some, the economic disruption Covid brought fuelled a transformation. For over two decades, since their marriage in 1992, Srikanth Arval, 54, and Prabhjoth, 47, had run the flourishing Orchids florists in Secunderabad. It had even expanded...a new branch came up in Visakhapatnam in 2003, another one at Gachibowli, west Hyderabad, in 2012. But flower prices shot up during the pandemic, and